Outside Ourselves (collection)

By Michael Jackson/Lionel Richie; Audre Lorde, Adrienne Rich and Pablo Neruda

We Are the World

There comes a time when we heed a certain call

When the world must come together as one

There are people dying

And it's time to lend a hand to life

The greatest gift of all

We can't go on pretending day by day

That someone somewhere will soon make a change

We're all a part of God's great big family

And the truth, you know,

Love is all we need

We are the world,

We are the children

We are the ones who make a brighter day

So, let's start giving

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There's a choice we're making

We're saving our own lives

It's true we'll make a better day

Just you and me

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Michael Jackson and Lionel Richie
ASIN: B003YP5D78
Publisher: Warner Bros. Publications Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 1985

INTRODUCTION

Over 30 years ago, more than 40 recording artists gathered to record these lyrics by Lionel Richie and Michael Jackson. Their goal: to raise awareness of widespread, life-threatening poverty in Africa. Over $75 million was raised to fight poverty on the continent. And for a brief moment the world did come together as one – united behind a cause. But rallies end and people are prone to return to their personal bubbles. This collection of poems considers the human tendency to turn a blind-eye to the plight of others. Fear, lack of knowledge, being too busy . . . . the reasons are endless. But the fact remains, the plight of the world will never change unless we all are willing to step . . . Outside Ourselves (a collection)

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A Litany for Survival by Audre Lorde

For those of us who live at the shoreline
standing upon the constant edges of decision
crucial and alone
for those of us who cannot indulge
the passing dreams of choice
who love in doorways coming and going
in the hours between dawns
looking inward and outward
at once before and after
seeking a now that can breed
futures
like bread in our children's mouths
so their dreams
will not reflect
the death of ours:

For those of us
who were imprinted with fear
like a faint line in the center of our foreheads

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learning to be afraid with our mother's milk
for by this weapon
this illusion of some safety to be found
the heavy-footed hoped to silence us
For all of us
this instant and this triumph
We were never meant to survive.

And when the sun rises we are afraid
it might not remain
when the sun sets we are afraid
it might not rise in the morning
when our stomachs are full we are afraid
of indigestion
when our stomachs are empty we are afraid
we may never eat again
when we are loved we are afraid
love will vanish
when we are alone we are afraid
love will never return
and when we speak we are afraid

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our words will not be heard

nor welcomed

but when we are silent

we are still afraid

So it is better to speak

remembering

we were never meant to survive –

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Audre Lorde
Book: The Black Unicorn
ISBN: 978-0393312379
Publisher: W.W. Norton and Company
Date (Month/Year): Aug 1995

TRANSITION

Adrienne Rich in her poem "Hunger" addresses not fear, but the fact that too often we choose to remain unaware of atrocities occurring outside our limited personal world. Without knowledge, just how do you quantify suffering?

According to the UN, 21,000 people die every day of hunger or hunger-related causes: One person every four seconds. This poetry selection is ~7 minutes long. By the time I am finished 105 people will already have starved to death . . . and sadly, children die most often.

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Hunger by Adrienne Rich

1.

A fogged hill-scene on an enormous continent,

intimacy rigged with terrors,

a sequence of blurs the Chinese painter's ink-stick

planned,

a scene of desolation comforted

by two human figures recklessly exposed,

leaning together in a sticklike boat

in the foreground. Maybe we look like this,

I don't know. I'm wondering

whether we even have what we think we have--

lighted windows signifying shelter,

a film of domesticity

over fragile roofs. I know I'm partly somewhere else--

huts strung across a drought-stretched land

not mine, dried breasts, mine and not mine, a mother

watching my children shrink with hunger.

I live in my Western skin,

my Western vision, torn

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and flung to what I can't control or even fathom.
Quantify suffering, you could rule the world.

2.

They rule the world while they can persuade us
our pain belongs in some order.
Is death by famine worse than death by suicide,
than a life of famine and suicide, if a black lesbian dies,
if a white prostitute dies, if a woman genius
starves herself to feed others,
self-hatred battening on her body?
Something that kills us or leaves us half-alive
is raging under the name of an "act of god"
in Chad, in Niger, in the Upper Volta--
yes, that male god that acts on us and on our children,
that male State that acts on us and on our children
till our brains are blunted by malnutrition,
yet sharpened by the passion for survival,
our powers expended daily on the struggle
to hand a kind of life on to our children,
to change reality for our lovers

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even in a single trembling drop of water.

3.

We can look at each other through both our lifetimes
like those two figures in the sticklike boat
flung together in the Chinese ink-scene;
even our intimacies are rigged with terror.
Quantify suffering? My guilt at least is open,
I stand convicted by all my convictions--
you, too. We shrink from touching
our power, we shrink away, we starve ourselves
and each other, we're scared shitless
of what it could be to take and use our love,
hose it on a city, on a world,
to wield and guide its spray, destroying
poisons, parasites, rats, viruses--
like the terrible mothers we long and dread to be.

4.

The decision to feed the world
is the real decision. No revolution

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has chosen it. For that choice requires

that women shall be free.

I choke on the taste of bread in North America

but the taste of hunger in North America

is poisoning me. Yes, I'm alive to write these words,

to leaf through Kollwitz's women

huddling the stricken children into their stricken arms

the "mothers" drained of milk, the "survivors" driven

to self-abortion, self-starvation, to a vision

bitter, concrete, and wordless.

I'm alive to want more than life,

want it for others starving and unborn,

to name the deprivations boring

into my will, my affections, into the brains

of daughters, sisters, lovers caught in the crossfire

of terrorists of the mind.

In the black mirror of the subway window

hangs my own face, hollow with anger and desire.

Swathed in exhaustion, on the trampled newsprint,

a woman shields a dead child from the camera.

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The passion to be inscribes her body.

Until we find each other, we are alone.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Adrienne Rich
Book: The Fact of a Doorframe
ISBN: 978-0393323955
Publisher: W.W. Norton and Company
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2002

TRANSITION

Are you too busy to be aware, to understand, to do something, however small? Pablo Neruda penned a deceptively simple poem about taking the time for a little bit of soul-searching which may help us make peace with ourselves and others.

Keeping Quiet by Pablo Neruda

Now we will count to twelve

and we will all keep still.

For once on the face of the earth,

let's not speak in any language;

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let's stop for one second,
and not move our arms so much.

It would be an exotic moment
without rush, without engines;
we would all be together
in a sudden strangeness.

Fisherman in the cold sea
would not harm whales
and the man gathering salt
would not look at his hurt hands.

Those who prepare green wars,
wars with gas, wars with fire,
victories with no survivors,
would put on clean clothes
and walk about with their brothers
in the shade, doing nothing.

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What I want should not be confused
with total inactivity.
Life is what it is about;
I want no truck with death.

If we were not so single-minded
about keeping our lives moving,
and for once could do nothing,
perhaps a huge silence
might interrupt this sadness
of never understanding ourselves
and of threatening ourselves with death.
Perhaps the earth can teach us
as when everything seems dead
and later proves to be alive.

Now I'll count up to twelve
and you keep quiet and I will go.

1 . . . 2 . . . 3 . . . 4 . . . 5 . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Pablo Neruda
Book: Extravagaria: A Bilingual Edition
ISBN: 9780374512385
Publisher: Noonday Press
Date (Month/Year): January 2001

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